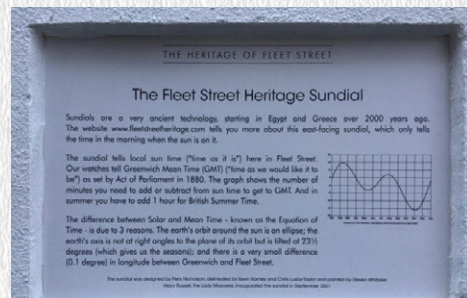


Bouverie Street

No. 138

THE HERITAGE of FLEET STREET

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Bouverie Street leads off the western end of Fleet Street, nearly opposite Fetter Lane. The street slopes quite steeply down towards the Thames.

In the Middle Ages, Bouverie Street did not exist. Its line was just the boundary between the Whitefriars Monastery to the east, and the land of the Templars to the West. After the Reformation, the land of the monastery was sold to Henry VIII's doctor. Then, around 1800, the site was sold to Jacob, 2nd Earl Radnor. He laid out Bouverie Street, named after the family name Pleydell-Bouverie. The short street, Pleydell Street, running west from Bouverie Street, was his mother's family name. The Radnor family still own the freeholds of much of the property around Bouverie Street.

Bouverie Street was the home of many newspapers and periodicals. Until the 1840s, the entrance to Bouverie Street was only 8 feet wide, and there was a house, number 62 Fleet Street, which stood over most of the present roadway.

On the eastern corner with Fleet Street were the offices of The Scotsman, whose head office is in Edinburgh. This paper was first published in 1817 as a radical political paper. It began daily publication in 1855, and remained a broadsheet until 2004.

The first detailed record of the people and businesses in Bouverie Street is the Post Office Directory of 1844. Nowadays, there are fewer than 10 entrance doors; then there were 25.

The 1844 list was: 2 Morton & Co, Sheffield plate ware; 3 Charles Courtier, bookseller; 4 John Beard, solicitor; 5 Haynes, printer; 6 Chesney & Williams, florists; 7 WS Paterson, attorney; 8 Anne Murphy, coal merchant; 9 Staniland & Long, attorneys; 11 S Sly, wood engraver; 12 S Watson & Sons, attorneys; 13 G Lawrence, jeweller; 15 Coopers Hotel; 17 & 18 Sussex Hotel; 20 Cutler & Reed, tailors; 21 R Hayward, button maker; 22 Wm. Ponton, surgeon & chemist; 25 Shotter, coal merchant.

By 1923, most of these small traders had been squeezed out by the press. The list then was: [West side] 4 Religious Tract Society; 6 Brown & Polson, corn flour manufacturers; 6 Newspaper Proprietors Assoc; 8 McGraw Hill, publishers and eight US journals; 8 Benn Brothers Ltd, publishers and nine UK journals; 10 Bradbury, Agnew & Co, printers & publishers; 10 Punch offices; 10 Agnew, barrister; 10 Bradbury, barrister; 11 Watson Sons & Room, solicitors; 12 New Catholic Press; 12 Patent Healthbelt Co; 13 Butcher & Sons, solicitors; 15 Gale & Co, druggists; [East side] 16 Advance Photo Co; 16A Digby Long & Co, publishers; 16A Allee & Cramp, printers; 16A Martin & Sons, book edge gilders; 19 to 22 Daily News offices, 19 to 22 Star Newspaper office; 23 to 29 Daily Mirror; 23 to 29 Sunday Pictorial; 30 News of the World; 33 Usher & Co, printers ink manufacturer; 33 Walker Bros, printers engineers.

By 2023, there have been more major changes. The Fleet Street Heritage Sundial has been painted on the blank wall on the west side of the entrance to Bouverie Street. The very large new building taking up the whole of the east side down to Magpie Alley is undergoing major redevelopment, largely behind its existing facade; it was occupied until 2021 by a large international law firm. Further down on the east side, Northcliffe House is also being redeveloped. So the list of occupiers is now very much shorter:

4 Delinian; 8 Fastmarkets; 10 Polish consulate; 11-12 car park; 13-15 Ashfield Healthcare and eleven associated companies.